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ACADEMIC VAULT

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THA 242: Costume and Appearance Design - Stage, Screen and Carnival

Dress a character with intention, from festival spectacle to film close-up

THEATRE & FILM

Theatre & Film Studies

Faculty of Arts
Theatre & Film Studies | 200L

OUTLINE ARCHIVE: 2018 - 2019 - 2025/2026

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

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Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

START HERE

Why this pack exists

Costume is character information made visible. This pack covers research and period sources, colour and silhouette, fabric behaviour under stage light and camera, make-up for stage versus screen, and the workflow from sketch to fitting to wardrobe maintenance.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Research and document a period or cultural costume source responsibly.
- Design costumes that communicate character, status and period.
- Distinguish stage make-up from screen make-up technique.
- Manage a wardrobe plot, fittings and maintenance for a production.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

Research and concept

Design begins with evidence, not mood boards alone.

- Identify the period, region, class and occasion of the production.
- Collect primary sources: photographs, museum catalogues, archival images.
- Note what a fabric, dye or accessory would actually have been available.
- Avoid mixing culturally distinct dress traditions into a generic 'African' look.
- Write a concept statement linking costume choices to character and theme.
- Credit your sources in a design file.

> **Specific, not decorative**
> A faded collar tells the audience about money. A random bright scarf tells them nothing.

Colour, silhouette and light

Costume must read from the back row and survive a close-up.

- Silhouette communicates status and period before detail is visible.
- Colour reads differently under tungsten, LED and daylight.
- Pattern can vibrate on camera; test on screen before approval.
- Fabric weight affects movement, heat and sound.
- Contrast separates a character from the set; blending creates anonymity.
- Test make-up under the actual lighting plot, not a bathroom mirror.

Workflow and wardrobe

A costume department is logistics as much as art.

- Costume plot: every character, scene and change listed in a table.
- Measurements, fittings and alteration schedules.
- Budget per character and per scene; track receipts.
- Quick-change plans and dressers for fast transitions.
- Maintenance: cleaning, repairs, labelling and storage.
- Returns, hires and security of borrowed items.

Costume is character before speech

A costume tells the audience who a person is, what they do, where they are and what has just happened to them - and it does so before a single line. That is why costume design begins with questions about the character, not with sketches: age, occupation, income, climate, period, social position, and the precise moment of the story.

The design brief is written, not imagined. For each character you need: the silhouette (the overall shape), the palette (colours and their relationships), the texture and weight of fabric, the condition of the garments, and the changes required by the action. A character who has been travelling needs creases and dust; a character who has just been humiliated needs a garment that no longer fits the way it did.

Students lose marks by designing "beautiful clothes" rather than characters. A test: show your sketch to someone who has not read the play and ask what they can tell about the person. If they can only say "she looks nice", the design has not done its job.

Designing for the medium

Stage and screen impose opposite constraints. On stage the audience is at distance, so silhouette, colour blocking and contrast carry the information; fine detail is wasted, and fabric that photographs poorly under stage light may read beautifully in the hand. On screen the camera decides: a close-up shows weave, stain and the fraying of a cuff, and the costume must survive that scrutiny without looking like a costume.

Practicalities govern both. Stage costume must allow the movement the blocking requires, survive quick changes, fasten reliably and be repairable. Screen costume must work across continuity - multiple takes, different days, the same mud on the same sleeve - which is why a continuity photograph of every costume state is a basic professional habit.

Carnival and festival costume is a third category with its own logic. There the body is a structure for spectacle: scale, colour, movement and lightness matter, because the costume is seen in motion and at distance, often at night, often in a crowd. Weight distribution and heat are design problems as real as the pattern.

> **Buy, borrow, build, alter**
> The professional order is cheapest first: source existing garments, alter them, build only what cannot be found. A student budget is a design constraint that should appear in your sketchbook as a cost column.

The costume plot and the paperwork

The costume plot is the document that makes a production run. A grid with characters down one side and scenes across the top, each cell listing the costume or change, immediately reveals collisions: two characters changing in the same ninety seconds, an actor in four costumes, a garment needed in scenes that cannot share a dressing room.

Behind the plot sit the working documents: the measurement sheet, the budget with receipts, the fittings schedule, the laundry and repair rota, and the continuity photographs. Costume work fails in production, not in design, and it fails for boring reasons - a zip that breaks, a hem that drops, a change with no dresser assigned.

Marks in assessment come from showing the whole chain: research, brief, sketches, fabric choice with justification, cost, construction plan and the running of the show. A beautiful sketch with no construction plan is half a design.

OUTLINE ARCHIVE

Session record: THA 242

2018 - 2019 - 2025/2026

Year demarcation matters: a course code that existed in 2018 may have been renumbered, merged or dropped by 2019, and the department now also runs a film track. Read the year label before you rely on a code. The current entry below is a compiled map - take it to your course rep or the departmental office and confirm it before registration.

2018 — Archived course description — ARCHIVED

- THA 242 Costume and Appearance Designs: From Festive Spectacle to Carnival
- History of costuming and make-up through the ages; textiles, cosmetology and fashion trends
- Sketching, match-ups, fittings, highlights, accessories and finishing

Source: unizik.edu.ng - Theatre & Film Studies course description (page dated 31 May 2018; original URL now returns 404) (retrieved 2026-10-22)

2019 — Archived programme listing — ARCHIVED

- THA 242 Costume and Appearance Designs, 3 credits, second semester, 200 level
- THA 344 Costume and Make-Up Design for the Stage and Screen follows at 300 level
- Costume sits within the technology and design stress area

What changed: The 2019 listing adds THA 344, extending costume design explicitly to screen work.

Source: arts.unizik.edu.ng - Theatre Arts programme and course map (page dated 18 Oct 2019; original URL now returns 404) (retrieved 2026-10-22)

2025/2026 — Compiled working map — CURRENT WORKING MAP

- Costume and appearance design remains the 200-level design core
- Screen make-up is now likely to be assessed given the film track
- Confirm whether materials are provided or self-funded for practicals

Source: Compiled by ZikShare from the archived 2018 and 2019 departmental pages plus the published stress areas; this is a working map, not an official handout (retrieved 2026-10-22)

Archive means: this records what a public departmental page listed in that year. It is not a guarantee of the current curriculum, and ZikShare is not affiliated with UNIZIK.

WORKED EXAMPLES

Do it once, slowly

These are not model answers to copy. They show the reasoning a strong student would use, step by step, so you can repeat the process on a question you have not seen.

1. Turning a script into a costume brief

A character is described only as "a market woman in her fifties, recently widowed". Build a brief.

1. Establish facts: occupation, income, climate, period, and the social role of mourning in the setting.
2. Choose silhouette: generous wrapper and blouse that permits sitting on the ground and carrying loads.
3. Choose palette: faded indigo and dark brown, with one item retained from before the death to show continuity of self.
4. Choose condition: worn edges at the shoulder where loads rest, fresh laundering but old fabric.
5. Choose texture: heavy cotton that reads at distance and survives heat.
6. List changes: the mourning garment in act one, the practical working dress in act three.
7. Write the cost and source for each item.

> **What to carry forward**
> A brief is a list of decisions with reasons. The sketch follows the reasoning.

2. Solving a quick change

An actor must change from a tailored suit to work clothes in forty seconds, offstage, with one dresser.

1. Count the fastenings: every button, zip and lace has a time cost.
2. Redesign the first costume with magnetic or press-stud closures hidden under a placket.
3. Build the second costume as a single piece that goes on over the head.
4. Pre-set both costumes in the order of removal, with the second on a marked rail.
5. Rehearse the change with the dresser at the same time as the scene before it.
6. Time it three times and add ten seconds of margin.

> **What to carry forward**
> Quick changes are engineered in the workroom and rehearsed like blocking.

EXAM TECHNIQUE

Questions with model answers

Written in the shape your course is usually examined, with the marking logic spelled out. Attempt each one under time before you read the outline.

Q1. How does costume design differ between stage and screen?

15 marks

1. State the viewing conditions: distance and light versus lens and close-up.
2. Explain what carries on stage: silhouette, colour blocks, contrast, durability.
3. Explain what carries on screen: texture, detail, continuity and realism under scrutiny.
4. Give a practical example of a garment that works in one medium and fails in the other.
5. Conclude that the medium sets the design problem, not merely the finish.

Q2. Explain the purpose of a costume plot and what it reveals.

10 marks

1. Describe the grid of characters against scenes.
2. Show what it exposes: change collisions, actor load, garment reuse, dresser requirements.
3. Link it to budget and laundry planning.
4. State that it is a production tool, not a design artefact.

REFERENCE

Glossary

Use these definitions in your own sentences; a copied definition rarely earns full marks.

Silhouette. The overall outer shape of a costume as read at distance.

Palette. The planned set of colours and their relationships across a production.

Costume plot. A grid listing each character's costume per scene, exposing changes and collisions.

Quick change. A costume change completed in seconds, engineered and rehearsed in advance.

Continuity. Consistency of costume state across takes, days and scenes.

Dresser. The crew member who assists with costume changes during performance.

Fitting. A session adjusting a garment to the performer's body and movement needs.

Breakdown. The deliberate ageing or distressing of a garment to look used.

Toile. A cheap test version of a garment used to check fit before cutting final fabric.

Practicality. A garment's ability to survive the movement, heat and changes a production demands.

Costume parade. A review of all costumes under performance lighting before technical rehearsals.

Pulling. Selecting existing garments from stock or hire rather than building new.

Your four-week plan

Week 1 - Read

Characters and constraints.

- Write a brief for three characters.
- Note every change the action requires.
- List budget and sourcing options.

Week 2 - Research

Evidence.

- Collect period and regional reference.
- Justify one fabric choice in writing.
- Sketch three silhouettes per character.

Week 3 - Build

Making it real.

- Make a toile for one garment.
- Cost the full plot.
- Plan fittings and a repair kit.

Week 4 - Run

Production discipline.

- Build the costume plot grid.
- Rehearse every quick change.
- Take continuity photographs of each state.

Where to read more

Entry-level texts you can find in the university library or a departmental reading list. Confirm editions with your lecturer.

- Any costume design text covering research, brief-writing and the costume plot.
- A stagecraft handbook section on wardrobe maintenance and quick changes.
- Photographic reference of carnival and festival costume construction in your region.

PRACTICE, NOT PREDICTION

Check your understanding

These questions are written for this pack to test the ideas above. They are not past examination questions and do not predict what your lecturer will set. Answer first, then compare.

1. What is a costume plot?

Answer: A table listing each character's costume for each scene, including changes, accessories and responsible crew.

2. Why must costume be tested under stage lighting?

Answer: Colour and texture shift under different light sources, so a costume that reads well in daylight may disappear on stage.

3. Give two differences between stage and screen make-up.

Answer: Stage make-up is heavier and more defined to read at distance; screen make-up is finer and controlled for close-ups and camera colour.

4. Why is cultural specificity important in design?

Answer: It communicates accurately and respectfully, avoiding the flattening of distinct traditions into a generic aesthetic.

5. What should a quick-change plan include?

Answer: The change, timing, dresser assignment, garment preparation and a rehearsal of the change.

Your 7-step action plan

Tick each step only when you have done it. A tick you cannot defend is worse than an empty box.

- [ ] Build a research file with five primary sources.
- [ ] Write a concept statement for one character.
- [ ] Draw two costume sketches with fabric swatches.
- [ ] Create a costume plot for a short play.
- [ ] Test make-up under stage lighting and photograph it.
- [ ] Cost your design and list hire items.
- [ ] Rehearse one quick change with a dresser.

Keep going

One pack will not carry a semester. Pair this with your lecture notes, tutorials, and the past questions your department actually releases. If a topic still feels unclear, take a specific question to your lecturer or course rep - "I do not understand the difference between X and Y" gets a better answer than "I do not understand this course".

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YOUR WORKSPACE

Notes, questions and things to ask

Use this page in class or during revision. Write questions you could not answer instead of copying slides.

Three ideas I can now explain without notes:

A question I still cannot answer:

For my lecturer or course rep:

Next revision action and date:

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